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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Criminal Paralegal role at your Basingstoke firm because criminal defence is an area where my practical case preparation and client communication experience is directly transferable, and I am looking to develop a specialism in criminal work.

Most of my experience has involved managing cases from instruction through to submission in time-sensitive environments. At BCLP, I was the only junior supporting an international arbitration team in the weeks before a significant submission deadline. I tracked outstanding actions across a large evidence set, coordinated document production and liaised with an external translator to keep everything on schedule. That kind of deadline pressure, where missing something has real consequences for a client, taught me more about case management than any formal training. At Citizens Advice East Berkshire, I manage the full lifecycle of matters myself: taking detailed client statements, identifying evidential gaps, drafting correspondence, and maintaining accurate case records. Many of my clients are in difficult personal circumstances, so I have had to develop a way of working through sensitive information carefully without losing sight of the practical steps that need to happen.

That client-facing element feels particularly relevant to criminal defence work, where clients are often under significant stress and need clear, honest information about process and options. I am used to translating complex procedural rules into straightforward guidance for people who have no legal background, and to doing so in a way that keeps their trust rather than losing it.

I am applying to this role because Basingstoke is within a manageable commute for me, and because criminal defence is an area I want to move into properly rather than touch on incidentally. The breadth of the caseload your team handles would give me the grounding to build that specialism seriously, working alongside solicitors with real experience in the field. That is the kind of environment where I know I develop quickest.

Yours sincerely,
Maria Silva